

143 Caiaphas

The high priest who judged it expedient that one man should die for the people.

Caiaphas was the high priest in Jerusalem through the whole of Jesus' ministry. He was the son-in-law of Annas, an earlier high priest, and he held the office for about eighteen years under Roman rule. After Jesus raised Lazarus, Caiaphas told the council that it was better for one man to die than for the whole nation to perish. John says he spoke more truly than he knew. Caiaphas presided at Jesus' night trial, put him under oath, tore his clothes at his answer, and sent him to Pontius Pilate. Weeks later he sat in judgment on Peter and John. He is a picture of religious power protecting itself, and of God's purpose working even through its opponents.

At a glance

Name	Caiaphas. The Jewish historian Josephus calls him Joseph Caiaphas
Office	High priest in Jerusalem, c. AD 18–36
Family	Son-in-law of Annas, a former high priest (John 18:13)
Party	Probably a Sadducee, like the high priest's circle in Acts 5:17
Key places	Jerusalem: the temple and his palace (Matthew 26:3, 57)
Key people	Annas, the council, Jesus, Pilate, Peter, John
Main passages	Matthew 26:57–68; John 11:47–53; 18:13–28; Acts 4

"Now Caiaphas was he, which gave counsel to the Jews, that it was expedient that one man should die for the people."

John 18:14, KJV

The life of Caiaphas

Dates are approximate (AD). His years in office come from Josephus. Gospel events follow the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30; on the other main view (AD 33), add about three years.

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|---|---|
| c. AD 28–29
<i>In office</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>High priest when John preaches
Luke dates John the Baptist's call to a time when "Annas and Caiaphas" were high priests. Caiaphas holds the office, while his father-in-law Annas keeps great influence. <i>Luke 3:1–2</i></div></div> |
| c. AD 30
<i>After Lazarus</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Counsels Jesus' death
After Lazarus is raised, the council fears that the Romans will take away "both our place and nation." Caiaphas says it is expedient that one man die for the people. <i>John 11:47–53</i></div></div> |
| c. AD 30
<i>Before Passover</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Plots at his palace
The chief priests, scribes and elders gather at the palace of the high priest, Caiaphas. They agree to take Jesus by subtlety and kill him, but not on the feast day. <i>Matthew 26:3–5</i></div></div> |
| c. AD 30
<i>Night</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Tries Jesus
Jesus is sent bound from Annas to Caiaphas. False witnesses disagree. Caiaphas puts Jesus under oath, hears his answer, tears his clothes and declares it blasphemy. <i>John 18:24; Matthew 26:57–66</i></div></div> |
| c. AD 30
<i>Morning</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Sends Jesus to Pilate
In the morning the council binds Jesus and leads him from Caiaphas to the Roman governor's hall of judgment. <i>Matthew 27:1–2; John 18:28</i></div></div> |
| c. AD 30
<i>Weeks later</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Questions the apostles
With Annas and others, he questions Peter and John about healing a lame man. The council forbids them to speak or teach in Jesus' name. <i>Acts 4:5–21</i></div></div> |

Key activities

Luke 3:2 and Acts 4:6 speak of Annas as high priest alongside Caiaphas. Annas had held the office earlier (c. AD 6–15, according to Josephus) and kept the title and much influence. Readers differ on exactly how the two shared authority.

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- 1 **Held the high priesthood.** He was "the high priest that same year," the year of Jesus' death. *John 11:49; 18:13*
 - 2 **Spoke an unknowing prophecy.** John says he spoke "not of himself," but prophesied that Jesus would die for the nation and gather God's scattered children. *John 11:49–52*
 - 3 **Plotted in secret.** He hosted the leaders who planned to arrest Jesus quietly. *Matthew 26:3–4*
 - 4 **Put Jesus under oath.** "I adjure thee by the living God, that thou tell us whether thou be the Christ, the Son of God." *Matthew 26:63–64*
 - 5 **Tore his clothes.** He rent his clothes, said Jesus had spoken blasphemy, and the council judged him worthy of death. *Matthew 26:65–66*
 - 6 **Handed Jesus to Rome.** He sent Jesus on to Pilate, since the council could not lawfully put anyone to death. *John 18:28–31*
 - 7 **Opposed the apostles.** He sat with the council that threatened Peter and John. *Acts 4:6, 18–21*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Caiaphas.

Old Testament

Echo: Exodus 28:29	The high priest bears Israel's names before the Lord
Echo: Isaiah 53:8	The servant "stricken" for the transgression of the people

New Testament

Luke 3:2	Named in Luke's dating of John the Baptist
John 11:47-53; 18:13-28	His counsel; Jesus sent from Annas to him and on to Pilate
Matthew 26:3-5, 57-68	The plot and the night trial (Mark 14:53-65 omits his name)
Acts 4:5-22	Among those who question Peter and John
Acts 5:17-40; 9:1-2	An unnamed high priest, probably Caiaphas if before c. AD 36
Echo: Hebrews 7:26-27	Jesus, the true high priest, offered once for all

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What reason did the council give for wanting to stop Jesus (John 11:47-48)?
2. *Understand:* John says Caiaphas prophesied without knowing it (John 11:51). What does that show about God's purposes?
3. *Apply:* Caiaphas chose what seemed safe for his position over what was true. Where are you tempted to do the same?
4. *Apply:* Jesus stayed silent before false witnesses (Matthew 26:62-63). How could you respond with restraint to an unfair criticism this week?